toppled backwards, they tripped on the string of wool and fell down. Splashes of muddy water splattered in all directions as they landed in the puddle I had made earlier. The more they tried to get up, the more they slipped and fell into it. In front of the swinging tyre, I stood with my hands resting on my waist as I saw them struggle, but only getting more dirty and stained. After standing there for one more moment, I ran back inside.

Of course, there were consequences. Maa and Papaji were called in by the principal. Maa was astonished to learn about what I had done and how I had done it. She and the principal kept discussing the treatment for my behaviour while I sat in one corner, looking at Papaji, who looked back at me. And then, he smiled. I smiled back.

* * *

During the discussion, the Excel girls spoke so loudly that the other girls could hardly be heard over them. Almost half a minute had passed, and I was still thinking about whether I would be able to make it through the GD. *Make yourself heard*, Papaji's words echoed in my mind. *All you need to do is to devise a strategy.* Without wasting any time, I started working on my strategy. *Don't worry, there are still five minutes left,* I said to myself. My plan was simple, but I didn't know if it would work. I listened to all the girls speak about the topic and recorded the facts that were given by them. Basically, I took the information from their arguments and educated myself right there.

'Tamil Nadu has almost 54 per cent of the basin area. Thousands of square kilometres of agricultural land are dependent on this river's water. The state of Tamil Nadu should maintain the flow,' Chest Number 16 said.

'But the river originates in Karnataka. I believe Karnataka should be given primary control,' Chest Number 25 said.

'I agree with Chest Number 25,' two other girls said.

'Mysore was the first to be allowed to construct a dam, and Madras had agreed to it in 1924. So Karnataka has the oldest right to maintain the flow of the Kaveri's waters,' Chest Number 68 said.